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# PHILOSOPHY OF ART

*a contemporary introduction*

Noël Carroll

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London and New York

First published in 1999
by Routledge
11 New Fetter Lane, London EC4P 4EE

Simultaneously published in the USA and Canada
by Routledge
29 West 35th Street, New York, NY 10001

*Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group*

This edition published in the Taylor & Francis e-Library, 2002.

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*British Library Cataloguing in Publication Data*
A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

*Library of Congress Cataloging in Publication Data*
A catalog record for this book has been requested

ISBN 0-415-15963-6 (hbk)
ISBN 0-415-15964-4 (pbk)
ISBN 0-203-19723-2 Master e-book ISBN
ISBN 0-203-19726-7 (GlassBook Format)

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# Art and form

## Part I
## Art as form

### Formalism

Like the expression theory of art, formalism arose as a reaction to representational theories of art. And also like the expression theory, it was prompted by striking shifts in artistic practice. The artistic practices that were particularly relevant to the emergence of formalism were the developments in painting and sculpture that have come to be known as modern art or modernism. Including Cubism and Minimalism, this art gravitates toward abstraction. Modern artists eschewed pictorial illustration, composing paintings out of often nonrepresentational shapes and masses of color. Their aim was not to capture the perceptual appearances of the world, but often to make images noteworthy for their visual organization, form, and arresting design.

Undoubtedly, one important cause of the evolution of this type of modern art was the advent of photography. Photography facilitated the production of pictures of remarkable verisimilitude both automatically and cheaply. Families could obtain portraits easily without the expenses in time and money incurred by posing for a painting. By the late nineteenth and early twentieth century, photography looked like it might put painting as imitation out of business. Artists had to find a new occupation, or at least a new style, in order to survive.

Abstraction was one of the ways they found to adapt to changing circumstances. From the turn of the twentieth century onwards, more and more painters became involved in the creation of nonobjective paintings that are primarily concerned with the articulation of the surface of the painting rather than with reference to "nature." Instead of treating the picture as a piece of glass—a mirror or a transparent windowpane onto the

world—painters began to explore the very texture of the glass itself. Rather than looking into it or through it, they turned their attention *at* it. This was painting for the sake of painting—painting that experimented with the possibilities of shape, line and color—not painting for the sake of showing the world.

The evolution of modern art occurred gradually. At first, impressionists "dissolved" the solidity of the picture plane, though one could still recognize objects in their paintings. But stand up close to an impressionist canvas and it becomes a pure surface on which the play of colors interacts delightfully. Then Cézanne carried the experimentation further, reducing objects to their underlying, geometrical shapes, like squares, spheres and cubes, until still lifes of recognizable fruits showed forth their basic visual structure. Cubism was not far behind. And with Cubism there dawned the era of abstract art, which has dominated much of twentieth-century painting.

As we saw in previous chapters, the representational theory of art ill-suited this sort of painting, since much abstract art represents nothing at all. Modern art, therefore, required a new sort of theory in order to be enfranchised as art. In the English-speaking world, perhaps the most influential theorist of the new art was Clive Bell. His book, *Art*, taught generations of viewers how to understand modern art. If nothing else, this book heralded a revolution in taste.

According to Bell, what determines whether or not a painting is art is its possession of *significant form.* That is, a painting is art if and only if it has a salient design. Though the importance of form was made especially apparent by the tendency of modern art toward abstraction, significant form was a property said to be possessed by all artworks, past, present and future. Significant form is comprised of arrangements of lines, colors, shapes, volumes, vectors, and space (two-dimensional space, three-dimensional space and the interaction thereof). Genuine art, on this view, addresses the imagination like the figures of Gestalt psychology, prompting the viewer to fill the artwork in such a way that we apprehend it as an organized configuration of lines, colors, shapes, spaces, vectors, and so on.

To see what Bell was getting at, consider a painting like David's *The Oath of the Horatii.* Though representational, the painting is particularly notable for its structure. It is centripetal, pulling the viewer inwards toward the center of the image where the arms and swords of the Horatii form a veritable X, a virtual target toward which all the rest of the force lines and vectors in the composition drive the eye. For Bell, it is the unified structure of paintings like this one that make them art. Its Gestalt properties compel our attention and encourage us to dwell on and contemplate the ways in which the composition interacts with our perceptual capacities, thereby

serving as pretext for us to explore our sensibility—to take note, for example, of how a particular diagonal line draws our attention to the foreground.

Clearly, this view of the art of painting is well suited for discussing modern abstract art. With its emphasis on structure, it tracks what is valuable in nonobjective and nonfigurative art more accurately than representational theories of art. As a theory of new directions in twentieth-century painting, it was obviously superior to the representational theory of art. Moreover, formalism also had the advantage of showing Europeans the value (the formal values) inherent in much of the nonimitative and "distorted" artworks from non-Western cultures which were beginning to appear with increasingly greater frequency in the museums of North Atlantic societies. Thus, formalism recommended itself not only because it identified what was important about modern art, but also because it provided a way to appreciate much otherwise inaccessible tribal art as well. That is, the relevant tribal artifacts, even if they deviated from the canons of strict verisimilitude, like modern abstract works, were art because they possessed significant form.

However, theorists like Bell did not argue simply that formalism was the best theory for newly emerging and newly acknowledged forms of art. Their claims were more ambitious. They maintained that formalism revealed the secret of all art for all times. They advanced formalism as the comprehensive theory of the nature of all art. They claimed that where the historical works, like *The Oath of the Horatii*, were artworks it was because they too possessed significant form.

Of course, most of the work in the tradition was representational. But the formalists claimed that where those works were genuine artworks, it was not, contra to the imitation theory of art, in virtue of their representational features that they enjoyed art status, but in virtue of their formal properties, such as unity. Thus, a consequence of formalism was that our idea of art history needed to be reconceived. Supposed works of art that had been counted as such merely because they were representational were to be dropped from the canon, while nonrepresentational or "distorted" works, like tribal carvings, that possessed significant form, had to be incorporated into art history.

From the formalist perspective art could be representational. But unlike the representational theorist, the formalist regarded representation as an incidental rather than as an essential property of artworks. Significant form was the hallmark of art. Indeed, formalists worried that representation could even get in the way of the appreciation of the formal interpretation of artwork—swamping it in floods of anecdotal observation.

This did not lead the formalist to declare that representation automatically disqualified a candidate from the order of art. Works like *The Oath of the Horatii* would be classified as artworks, but not in light of their

representational content, only in terms of their formal properties. For the formalist, the representational content of an artwork is *strictly irrelevant* to its status as art. Form is all that makes the difference.

Formalism found its natural home in the realm of painting. Nevertheless, it was easy to extend the view to other arts. Obviously, most orchestral music is not representational. This was always a vexation for the representational theory of art. But it is scarcely controversial to describe music in terms of the temporal play of aural forms. Listening for the recurring themes and variations and the sequencing of audio structures is ground-zero for musical appreciation. In fact, formalism provides an even more comprehensive approach with respect to music than the expression theory, since as we saw in the last chapter, not all music is expressive. However, arguably, it all possesses form. Could it even be music, the formalist might ask rhetorically, if it did not have form? Formless sound, so it might be said, just is not music.

The tenets of formalism were also extended to dance, due to the influential criticism of theorists like André Levinson, while the notion of form became a shibboleth in modern architectural theory. Literature might appear to be a more difficult artform to explicate exclusively in terms of form. However, not only could formalists point to the centrality of features of poetry like meter, rhyme and generic structures (such as the sonnet *form*); but stories too possess formal features such as narrative structures and alternating points of view that theorists could claim lay at the heart of the literary experience. Formalists, of course, could not deny that most literature possessed representational content. Instead, formalists, notably the Russian Formalists, argued that such content only serves to motivate literary devices, and ultimately it is the play of literary devices that accounts for the art status of poems, novels and the like—at least in those cases that are truly artistic.

In certain ways, formalism is a very egalitarian doctrine. Previously, certain pictures were classified as artworks in virtue of their possession of certain highly valued representational content—historical subjects, religious subjects, mythological subjects, and so on. But under formalism, anything could be art—anything could play in the game—so long as it possessed significant form. Formalism revised how one thought about art. Some amorphous works which were nevertheless representational were cashiered from the order of art, while other hithertofore lowly, disenfranchised works, such as ingenious decorative art, could assume their rightful position alongside artworks with uplifting subject matter. Thus, formalism can acknowledge the artistry of the work of women quilters, for instance, that the representational theory of art ignores.

But formalism is not simply attractive because it is open to a greater range of achievement than representational theories of art. It can also claim several powerful arguments in its favor. The first of these can be called the

"common denominator argument." This argument begins with the unexceptionable presupposition that if anything is to count as a necessary condition of art status, then it must be a property had by every artwork. So much is built into the definition of what it is to be a necessary condition.

Next the formalist invites us to consider rival claimants for the role of necessary conditions for art status. Form, of course, is one. But as we've seen, so is the possession of representational and/or expressive properties. Yet, not all artworks are representational. Think of many string quartets, as well as purely decorative abstract designs, such as the work of a Josef Albers, Dan Flavin, or a Kenneth Noland. Nor are all works of art possessed of expressive qualities; as we saw in the previous chapter, some artists even aspire to remove expressive qualities from their work, striving to create works of pure formal interest, such as many of the abstract ballets of George Balanchine. Thus, not all works of art are expressive.

That leaves us with form as the most viable candidate. Moreover, though we have arrived at this conclusion indirectly by negating competing alternatives, the result rings true directly, since all artworks do seem at the very least to possess form. Form is the common denominator among all artworks, the property that they all share—whether they be paintings, sculpture, drama, photography, film, music, dance, literature, architecture or whatever. At least at first glance, formalism seems to be the most promising hypothesis we've seen so far—one that is much more comprehensive than the representational or expression theories of art.

Stating the argument schematically, then:

1 Only if x is a feature of all artworks is x a plausible contender to be an essential (necessary) feature of art.
2 Either representation or expression or form is a feature of all artworks.
3 Representation is not a feature of all artworks.
4 Expression is not a feature of all artworks.
5 Therefore, form is a feature of all artworks.
6 Therefore, form is a plausible contender to be an essential feature of all artworks.

This argument suggests that form is the most plausible contender (out of the best-known competitors) to serve as a necessary condition for art. So, x is an artwork only if it possesses form. The common denominator argument, however, does not provide us with a sufficient condition for art status, since many things other than art also possess form. Indeed, the condition is too broad as stated, because, in some sense everything might be said to possess form.

Thus, the formalist needs to say that "x is art, only if it possesses *significant* form," though this, of course, will still not differentiate art from many other things, since it is the case that a well-made speech on the

economics of dairy farming and a mathematical theorem may, as well, possess significant form. In order to establish that the possession of significant form provides a sufficient condition for art status, the formalist needs another argument. Standardly, the formalist attempts to meet this challenge by adverting to the *function* of artworks in contrast to other things.

Speeches and mathematical theorems may possess significant form, but it is not their primary purpose to display their form. The primary function of a speech about dairy economics is to report on a situation. A mathematical proof is undertaken in order to come to a conclusion. These activities may result in products that are remarkable for their form, but exhibiting their form is not what they are primarily about. If they lacked significant form, they could still be eminently serviceable vehicles for discharging their functions. Art is different from these other activities insofar as it is, so the formalist suggests, uniquely concerned with displaying form.

No other human activity, the formalist alleges, has the exhibition of form as its special or peculiar province of value. It is its primary preoccupation with the exploration of form that demarcates the dominion art from other human practices. Whereas representational content is not irrelevant to economics speeches or mathematical theorems, representation is always strictly irrelevant to artworks.

Art may be concerned with religious or political themes, moral education or philosophical world-views. But so are many other things. Indeed, many other things like sermons, pamphlets, newspaper editorials, and philosophical treatises generally do a better job of conveying cognitive and moral information than art does. What is special about art is that, above all else, it is concerned with discovering formal structures that are designed to encourage our imaginative interplay with them. In fact, many formalists would argue that artworks ultimately contain cognitive, moral and other types of representational content solely in order to motivate the display of formal properties. A sloppy sermon will be accounted a satisfactory one, so long as it moves an audience to divine adoration; but nothing will count as art if it fails to display form significant enough to intrigue us.

The doctrine of formalism accords nicely with many of our intuitions about art. We regard much of the art of the past as worthwhile, despite the fact that the ideas it represents are now known to be obsolete. This contrasts with physics, where discredited theories are long forgotten and rarely consulted. This is so because the primary function of physics is to give us information about the universe. But the information about the universe contained in many past artworks is believed to be wrong. So, why is it that we still read Lucretius's *On the Nature of Things* or Hesiod's *Theogany*?

The formalist can explain this; it is due to their formal virtues, as is also the case with the architecture of Angkor Wat, whose representation of the cosmos is known to be false.

Moreover, it often transpires that we criticize certain films for being too message-oriented, while commending other films as being good of their kind. Why is this? The formalist has a ready answer: a dumb, amoral film may be formally interesting—it may deploy its formal devices (editing, camera movement, color schemes, and so on) —in ways that address our sensibility in a compelling manner. In many such films the thematic content is negligible, even silly, but its formal organization is riveting, whereas a film with a big idea, however important and earnestly expressed, may strike us as altogether, as they say, uncinematic.

We may feel with such a big-idea picture that "it's not really a movie, is it?" Or, as the adage goes among film-makers and film viewers: "If you want to send a message, use Western Union." A film with a heartfelt theme may be some kind of sermon, but it is not cinematic art, unless it exhibits significant form. Thus, formalism appears in tune with certain of our intuitions about art, especially about the centrality of formal inventiveness. And this is a tempting consideration on its behalf.

The preceding considerations suggest an argument for the view that a sufficient condition for art is that an artwork is something designed with the primary function of exhibiting significant form. We can call this the function argument.

1 Only if x is a primary function that is unique to art is x a sufficient condition for art.
2 The primary function unique to art is either representation, expression or the exhibition of significant form for its own sake.
3 Representation is not a primary function unique to art.
4 Expression is not a primary function unique to art.
5 Therefore, the primary function unique to art is the exhibition of significant form for its own sake.
6 Therefore, the exhibition of significant form for its own sake is a sufficient condition for art.

Here, it is important to note that by function is meant the purpose that the work is intended or designed to discharge. This qualification is required for two reasons. First, if the notion of an intention is not added, then natural beauties may be counted as artworks, since they may possess significant form, though they are not artworks.

And second, if the simple possession of significant form were the litmus test of art status, then many works of art would have to be discounted just because the artist fails to invest her work with significant form. But artwork is still art,

even if it fails to discover a significant form—that is, many artworks are formally inadequate, and bad for that reason, yet they are still artworks. One must allow space in the world for bad art; a theory cannot render bad art nonexistent.

If one counts only work that achieves significant form as art, then only what we now call good art will count as art. But, at the same time, we classify bad art as art too which presupposes, of course, that bad artworks are art. To categorize only good art as art results in a commendatory theory of art, one where art=good art. However, that leaves us at a loss as to where to place bad art. Consequently, in order to avoid making formalism into a commendatory theory, rather than a classificatory theory, we need to add to the formula that an artwork be such that it is *intended* primarily to exhibit significant form. It may fail in its intention. Such should be the story of bad art, according to the formalist.

Representation is not a sufficient condition for art status, since representation is not a function unique to art. Ordinary cereal boxes wear representations on their faces, designed, as they are, to convey information. Nor is expression a function unique to art. Hate-speech is expressive, but almost never art.

On the one hand, representation and expression are too exclusive to serve as necessary conditions for art status. On the other hand, they are not sufficient to distinguish artworks from other things. Consequently, insofar as representation and expression are each both too inclusive and too exclusive, they afford neither necessary nor sufficient conditions for art status. Therefore, formalism appears to offer the most plausible theory of art. That is:

> x is a work of art if and only if x is designed primarily in order to possess and to exhibit significant form.

This theory accords neatly with our experience of much modern art, where we attend primarily to such things as the way in which one block of color advances on the picture plane while another recedes. And formalism does an excellent job of explaining why we still appreciate past art whose representational content is outmoded. The formalist says that we still appreciate its organization—for instance, its compositional unity.

## Objections to formalism

Formalism is the doctrine that something is an artwork just in case it is designed with the primary intention that it possess and exhibit significant form. This

does not entail that artworks cannot be representational, since representations can have significant form. However, such artifacts are not art because they are representational, but because of the significant form they display or attempt to display. That is, representational content is always strictly irrelevant to the determination of whether or not a candidate is an artwork. Thus, Picasso's *Guernica* is not art because it depicts an aerial bombardment, but because its juxtaposition of figures is arresting.

Unquestionably, formalism picks out what is important with much art. But is it an adequate, comprehensive theory of all art? We can begin to investigate this question by asking whether the *primary* intention to exhibit significant form is a necessary property of all art.

A casual review of art history would suggest that it is not. Much traditional art was religious or political, designed primarily to glorify gods and saints, important religious events, military victories, the coronations of kings, the signing of covenants and treaties, and so on. The primary purposes of the stained glass windows in cathedrals and of illustrations of the life of Buddha are educational—they are meant to enable viewers to recollect important religious doctrines and morals. A great deal of traditional art commemorates events—it is designed to recall to the mind of the viewer historic moments and to remind them of the commitments that such events have bequeathed to them as members of a common culture, race, or nation.

This much is obvious, and such intentions can generally be read off the surface of the works in question. The Arch of Triumph in Paris is primarily designed to celebrate victories; the Lincoln Memorial is designed to observe emancipation. Who could think otherwise? But if many artworks are primarily designed to discharge broader social agendas, then the primary intention to exhibit significant form cannot be a necessary condition for all art, since it should be fairly evident that much art (most art?) is primarily designed with other functions in mind.

To this objection, the formalist may reply that our problem comes from interpreting her requirement in the singular rather than the plural. An artifact, it might be said, can have more than one primary function and these may co-exist. The idea is this. An altarpiece may be designed to observe the resurrection of Jesus and to recall to the viewer the lesson of his sacrifice. That is one of its purposes. However, another purpose of equal weight is that the viewer appreciate the design of the work. The artist has two purposes: to celebrate the resurrection of Christ and to make a beautiful object. Both are simultaneously in the forefront of the artist's intention.

The formalist might add that this latter intention is why we visit churches of denominations of which we are not members—to appreciate the obviously intended beauty and subtlety of the work. The formalist will

argue that such works had to be designed with the intention that the work be so appreciated, lest the artist would not have lavished such care in the execution of its design. Thus artifacts that have been made with the primary intention to acquit some social function will, if they are genuine artworks, also be made with another equally motivating and, therefore, primary intention, namely the intention to exhibit significant form for viewers to appreciate.

Or, if the notion of two or more *primary* intentions sounds virtually self-contradictory to you, the formalist may accommodate your misgivings by weakening his view so that it claims no more than that something is an artwork only if the artifact in question has been made with an intention (which may or may not be the primary intention, but only a secondary, tertiary, or even more remote intention) that the work exhibit significant form. Surely that does not appear unreasonable. Why would the artist have taken the pains to create a significant formal arrangement, unless she intended it to be exhibited and engaged?

However, this conceptual maneuver is inadequate. For example, in cultures all around the world, certain demon figures are common. The primary function of these figures is protection—they are supposed to ward off intruders and trespassers. They tell outsiders "Beware of the demon," or they are intended to cause the illusion that the demon is already on the loose. These figures are meant to scare people off.

Furthermore, we typically count such sculptures as artworks. They populate museums worldwide and are coveted pieces in private collections. Yet it is immensely implausible to suppose that these works are designed with any intention to exhibit significant form. They will not frighten anyone away, if they simultaneously invite the appreciation of significant form. Their creators must know this. So they cannot have intended the works to exhibit significant form.

Now it may be the case that these demon figures possess significant form, but it is not part of the artist's intention—primary or otherwise—to display it, since if the artist exhibits significant form successfully, he risks cancelling out the terrifying aspect of his work, thereby defeating, or, at least, compromising his purposes. Thus, it cannot be the case universally that the intention to exhibit significant form underwrites every artwork.

Counterexamples such as these are likely to incline the formalist to rethink the way in which this necessary condition is framed. Problems seem to be erupting with respect to the requirement that the exhibition of significant form be designed or intentional. So, why not avoid the problems by dropping the expectation that the display be intentional and merely require that the artworks possess and exhibit significant form? But, as we have already seen, that way lies trouble.

On the one hand, there is the aforementioned problem of bad art. Art

may be bad because it lacks significant form, but it is still art. The imagined revision of the significant form requirement leaves us with no way to speak of bad art, but only of nonart. But bad art is not nonart; Antarctica is nonart. Bad art is still art, though art of an inferior sort. So the revision of the condition is too exclusive; it cannot serve as a necessary condition for art status.

On the other hand, there is also the problem of nature. Nature can have significant form—just study the play of color of country foliage in autumn or listen to the rhythms of a rippling brook. But nature is not art. Where the requirement is that the possession and exhibition of significant form be designed, the formalist can exclude nature from the corpus of art, since the beauties of nature have been intended by no one. But once the intention requirement is dropped, then the formalist's definition must count nature as art, and this is too inclusive. So by jettisoning the requirement of the relevant intention, the revised formulation fails to provide a sufficient condition for art status.

Thus, the formalist appears trapped in a dilemma. Either she regards the intention to display significant form as a necessary condition of art status or she does not. If she does, then her condition will be too exclusive, discounting the art status of demonic sculptures. But if she does not regard the pertinent intention as required, then she must confront the problem of excluding bad art, while including nature under her conception of art. None of these alternatives seem particularly savory ones.

Nor is the intention component the only unstable part of the formalist's theory. The notion of significant form itself is regrettably indeterminate. What is it exactly? The formalist has given us no way to discriminate between significant form and insignificant form. We have been given some examples, but no principles to tell the difference. What makes one juxtaposition of shapes significant, and another not? We have no way to decide. Thus, obscurity lies at the heart of formalism; the theory is useless, because its central term is undefined.

The formalist might say that a work has significant form, if it is arresting. But that is not enough, since a work can be arresting for reasons other than formal ones, or even in virtue of formal properties that are not significant in the formalist's sense—such as its unusual monotone color. How, without a characterization of significant form, will we know whether a work is arresting because it possesses significant form, rather than for some other reason?

Often formalists attempt to repair this shortcoming by saying that significant form is such that it causes a special state of mind in viewers. But that is an unhelpful suggestion, unless the formalist can define that state of mind. Otherwise we are left with one undefined concept posing as a definition of another—which is effectively equivalent to having no definition at all.

Nor can the formalist say that significant form causes that peculiar state of mind in percipients that is the apprehension of significant form, since such a definition is circular. We would have to already possess the concept of significant form in order to tell whether a mental state was indeed an apprehension of significant form.

In the next chapter, we will look at further attempts to develop the idea that artworks evoke certain distinctive states of mind. Until then we cannot fully foreclose this possible way of defining significant form. However, at this point, the burden of proof falls to the formalist, since, on the face of it, it appears unlikely that there is a distinctive state of mind elicited by all artworks. That is, since there are so many different kinds of artworks that require all sorts of different kinds of mental responses, it is doubtful that there is just one mental state that they all share. Does a feminist novel really engender the same kind of mental state that a Fabergé egg does? Until such hurdles can be crossed, the suggestion that significant form can be defined in terms of the distinctive mental state it provokes is moot.

But perhaps the formalist will say that we really don't need a definition of significant form here. Everybody knows what it is. Everyone can pick it out. It involves proportions, notably ones like the Golden Section, symmetries, asymmetries, balances, striking imbalances, tension, unity, contrast, and the like. In ordinary language we can pick out examples of significant form with a surprising degree of convergence. We may not call them significant form. But if asked to pick out examples of works of art with strong formal qualities—especially unity—we can do it with a very high ratio of agreement. We know what to look for: repeating motifs, equilibria, strong contrasts, symmetries, and so on. We can apply the notion of significant form without a definition. Therefore, the formalist suggests, the lack of a characterization of significant form is not the huge impediment that we have made it out to be.

But if we take the formalist at his word and use our ordinary language intuitions to apply the concept of significant form, there are many counterexamples to the thesis that significant form (and/or the intention to exhibit it) is a necessary condition for art. The composer John Cage created a piece called 4' 33? which is generally regarded as a major work of twentieth-century art. It is comprised of a set of instructions: a pianist is to sit at a piano and open a score, but not to strike the keys. The performance consists of all the ambient sounds that occur within the ensuing interval of four minutes and thirty-three seconds. If someone coughs and scrapes their chair along the floor, that is part of the piece. If a cellular phone rings, or a moving van rumbles past outside, that too is part of the piece. Likewise if someone turns on a radio and we hear Howard Stern preening. Then the pianist closes the score and the piece is over.

Obviously, what is heard from performance to performance will vary with locations. The sounds that make up 4' 33? have no predetermined formal order;

the composition is aleatoric in that regard. The point of the piece is to draw our attention to the often neglected sounds of everyday life—to contemplate them at least for four minutes and thirty-three seconds.

This is an artwork, but if we use our ordinary language intuitions, we will not say that it possesses significant form. Indeed, it will appear formless to us—as formless as the array of everyday sounds that accost us on a daily basis. Nor is it plausible to attribute to Cage the intention to exhibit significant form. He has contrived a situation where formlessness is the designated object of our attention. But if with respect to the criteria inherent in ordinary language it is possible, as in the case of 4' 3?, to make an intentionally formless artwork successfully, then neither significant form nor the intention to exhibit it is a necessary condition for art.

Moreover, Cage is not the only artist to explore formlessness—in our ordinary language sense—intentionally. The sculptor Robert Morris is another. His piece *Steam* emits steam from under a bed of stones, and the resulting "figure" is as formless as fog. Likewise his 1968 sculpture *Untitled (Threadwaste)* is made up of threadwaste, asphalt, mirrors, copper tubing and felt, scattered over the floor, while, in the same year, he composed *Untitled (Dirt)* where, on a bed of dirt, he distributed grease, peat moss, and pieces of brick, steel, aluminum, brass, zinc and felt with apparent randomness. Employing ordinary language, I predict that the first thing that comes to mind upon encountering these pieces is "What a mess!" If we found identical collections of debris on our living room floors, we'd want them cleaned up. And if asked to describe them, I suggest that we'd say they were formless, as formless as garbage heaps (which is what they look like).

Morris's works can be defended as art on several grounds. One can argue that they are about exploring the question of "What is art?" Or, an expression theorist might propose that they are meant to arouse feelings of disgust, or revulsion and to project the quality of abjectness so that audiences can contemplate this feeling, both in terms of its tones and its conditions. But both interpretations require that the works strike us as formless, in the ordinary sense of the word. Thus, contra formalism, there are formless works of art.

Perhaps the formalist will say that these works are not really formless. But the ambient sounds of 4' 33? are indiscernible from the ambient sounds of everyday life that we customarily call formless, while the steam and scrap piles that Morris has made are indiscernible from ordinary phenomena that is regarded as amorphous. They lack symmetries, balance, equilibrium, studied contrast and counterpoint, and every other criterion that we typically use to apply the concept of form in common discourse.

What lacks form in life must also lack form in art where the artworks in question are perceptually indiscernible from their real-world counterparts. If mounds of refuse are formless, so are Morris's sculptures. Thus, it is not the case that artworks universally possess and exhibit significant form, so it is false that

significant form, as understood in ordinary language, or the intention to produce it is a necessary feature of all art.

As a last resort, the formalist may contend that these works by Cage and Morris actually do possess and exhibit significant form intentionally. For once one understands what these artists are up to, one can see that their choices were apposite. Form follows function. Where the artist wants to call attention to the vagrant sounds of everyday life, the design of 4' 33? is brilliant. It gets the job done with deliberate economy and verve. So, appearances notwithstanding, the work of Cage and Morris does exhibit formal virtues.

There is much truth in the preceding argument. However, it is not really available to the formalist at this point in the discussion. For in order to propose an interpretation like this of something like *Untitled (Dirt)*, one would have to know antecedently that it is an artwork and not an ordinary mess on the garage floor. That is, in order to attribute significant form to *Untitled (Dirt)* you would first have to be able to classify it as an artwork. But the formalist cannot do that, since the formalist needs to be able to identify significant form independently in order to classify something as art. He has not defined art, if we must first know whether the candidate is art—in terms of logical priority—in order to determine whether it possesses significant form. That would result in circularity. In a gesture of desperation, the formalist may say "let's stopping talking about significant form and just talk about form," understood loosely as any relation between the parts of a whole. Something is art, only if it possesses and exhibits form. But this is extremely unhelpful. It does not provide a necessary condition for art, since there are artworks—like the monochrome paintings of Ad Reinhardt, Yves Klein, and Robert Ryman— that have no parts (they are blocks of single colors). Moreover, reading the formalist's theory in this way would defeat any hope of his securing a sufficient condition for art, since everything that has parts probably has form in the loose sense, and not everything is art. Indeed, in his *Discourse on Metaphysics*, Leibniz notes that everything, no matter how apparently formless, has form in the sense that a mathematical equation can be devised to represent it. But if this is so, form, in the unqualified sense, is not a sufficient condition for anything in particular. It should also be evident that even if we revert to the earlier statement of the theory—that x is art if and only if it is primarily designed to possess and exhibit significant form—the formalist has not secured a sufficient condition for art. For in our ordinary way of speaking, there are things that are primarily designed to possess and exhibit signifcant form that are not artworks. Consider a mathematical theorem where a proof already exists, but where it is a cumbersome one, involving many steps. A mathematician may decide to produce a more elegant proof of a truth already known. Her objective is not primarily to prove a conclusion, but to exhibit a more economical—as mathematicians say, "a more beautiful" —way of rendering the theorem. Her results have significant form, describable in terms of elegance. But a

mathematical proof, even one like this, is never a work of art. Insofar as the formalist's theory forces him to accept it as one, the theory is overly inclusive. Nor is mathematics the only source of counterexamples here. Athletes and chessmasters can intend primarily to exhibit significant form in their activities.

But what of the earlier arguments on behalf of formalism—the common denominator argument and the function argument? By now we have assembled enough considerations to see what is amiss with each of them. We have seen that form, in the ordinary sense, is not a property of all artworks. Thus, the fifth step in the common denominator argument is false, even though it is a logically valid conclusion from earlier premises. That indicates that one of the earlier premises was false. The first premise seems true by definition, while third and fourth premises are the fruits of the preceding two chapters. So the problem, if there is a problem, is with the second premise.

The second premise states that "Either representation, expression, or form is a feature of all artworks." This premise is inadequate because it has not listed all the possible alternatives—both positively and negatively. Negatively, it has overlooked the alternative that there may be no feature that is a feature of all artworks. Positively, it has not enumerated other candidates, such as the ones to be explored in future chapters, that may identify a feature of all artworks. So, step five has been derived illegitimately from a premise that is incomplete. Moreover, as we have seen, when we examine the claim that form is a feature of all artworks independently of the rest of the argument, it is false. So the possession of form is not a necessary condition of art.

Parallel problems beset the function argument. There the fifth step— that the primary function unique to art is the exhibition of significant form for its own sake—is false. Certain mathematical theorems, athletic performances, and chess games may also be meant to exhibit significant form for its own sake. And once again the difficulty can be traced back to the second premise: that the primary function unique to art is either representation, expression, or the exhibition of significant form for its own sake. This premise is flawed just because it ignores the possibilities that there may be no primary function unique to art or that it resides somewhere other than in representation, expression or the expression of form. If the second premise were stated with proper closure (i.e., if all the alternatives were enumerated and explored), step five would not follow. Moreover, the notion that the primary function unique to art is the exhibition of significant form is false anyway. As we have seen, it is too inclusive. Therefore, formalism has failed to establish a sufficient condition for art.

Perhaps the most radical thought advanced by formalism is that representation, where it occurs in artworks, is always strictly irrelevant to art status. It is in virtue of this idea that formalists are often criticized for being politically incorrect, or, at least, insensitive. They regard fascist productions—like T*he Triumph of the Will*—as art because it exhibits arresting formal

structures cinematically, whereas many politicos are predisposed to classify it not as art, but as obscenity. That is, the politicos think that what *Triumph of the Will* represents is relevant to its art status, while the formalist regards the Nazi representational content as strictly irrelevant.

We cannot adjudicate this particular debate about *Triumph of the Will* here; perhaps the formalist is right in this case. But the deeper formalist supposition—that representation is always strictly irrelevant to art status—is mistaken. The reason for believing this is simply that in a large number of cases artworks possess and exhibit significant form just because of their representational content. That is, in many cases, the possession and exhibition of significant form depend upon the representational properties of the pertinent artworks. Thus, if significant form were, as the formalist alleges, criterion for art status, and if, additionally, in many cases significant form depends upon representation, it could not possibly be the case that representation is always strictly irrelevant to art status.

Consider an example. In Bruegel's *The Fall of Icarus* (see Figure 1), the foreground is dominated by a farmer plowing furrows; in the background, there is a seascape, stretching to the horizon, and some mountains on either side of the shore. As well, there are two ships riding the water. But if you look closely at the lower right-hand corner of the painting, there is also a leg, attached to a submerged body, splashing in the surf.

The leg, of course, belongs to Icarus, who flew so close to the sun that the wax fixative in his wings liquified, plunging him to earth. We know this because of the title of the painting. The painting is expressive of insouciance, observing the irony of the way in which everyday life goes on quietly and imperviously, while legendary events occur unnoticed. But the painting also has significant form—a delightful off-centeredness or asymmetry that underscores the contrast between the quotidian and the momentous.

That is, the narrative center of the painting—the fallen Icarus—is placed off to the side, where he goes almost unremarked; whereas everyday "background" details hold centerstage. Narrative structure and compositional conventions pull in opposite directions in a way that sets up a dynamic formal tension in the painting and in our perception of it. It bounces our eye back and forth between the farmer and Icarus. It initiates an interesting formal disturbance in the otherwise tranquil—or deceptively tranquil—scene.

But to appreciate this formal structure it is necessary to attend to the representational content of *The Fall of Icarus*. The pertinent formal tension could not be detected and appreciated—indeed, it would not be there—were the representational elements in the painting strictly irrelevant. From the formalist point of view, *The Fall of Icarus* has significant form and is art because of features like this interesting structural tension between

*Figure 1 Landscape with the Fall of Icarus,* Pieter Bruegel the Elder, c. 1558, oil on canvas, mounted on wood, 73.5×112 cm, Musées Royaux des Beaux-Arts de Belgique, Brussels.

"centers," both narrative and compositional. But it only possesses this structural tension in virtue of its representational elements. Thus, inasmuch as the possession of significant form often depends upon representation, and art status allegedly depends on significant form, it cannot be the case that representation is always strictly irrelevant to art status.

This problem is even more evident if we turn our attention to literature. Significant form in literature is generally inconceivable without representation. How can one discern tragic structure without taking heed of what is being represented? Even the reversal in the last two lines of an English sonnet depends on what is represented. Perhaps some aspects of literature are purely abstract—like alliteration—but even here the case is somewhat mixed, since a great deal of the form in poetry is what is called imitative form, and imitative form, as the very name implies, requires attention to what is represented in order to take hold. Thus, a great deal of form in literature is dependent on representation. So once again, if the formalist wants to maintain that only the exhibition of significant form is the sign of art, then he must concede that representation is not always irrelevant to art status. How could it be, if significant form frequently supervenes on representation?

## Neoformalism

The utter neglect of the relevance of content to art status is the most glaring problem of formalist theories of art. Thus an obvious way to go about repairing formalism is to provide some accommodation for content. The neoformalist does this by making content a necessary condition for art. But, of course, content alone, even if it is traditional artistic content (such as the Madonna and Child), is not enough to secure art status; more is needed. A candidate must also possess form. But many things—such as multiplication tables—which are not art possess form and content. So it must be something about the way in which form and content are related in a work that makes it an artwork. Here, the neoformalist proposes that in an artwork, properly so called, form and content are related in a satisfyingly appropriate manner.

So, for neoformalism:

> x is an artwork if and only if (1) x has content (2) x has form and (3) the form and the content of x are related to each other in a satisfyingly appropriate manner.

"Form" and "content" are the two key terms in this definition. But what exactly do they mean? One popular way of construing this contrast is to think of it in terms of the analogy between a container and what it contains. Champagne has no form, unless it is placed in some vessel—a bottle or a glass. The container gives it shape. Similarly, form is often thought of as the container that gives shape to content. Content is the stuff of the artwork; form is what gives its contour and character.

This analogy—that form is to the content as container is to the contained—is very common. But it is also inadequate when applied to artworks, since, when it comes to art, it is generally impossible to distinguish between what is contained and a container. The content of Rimsky-Korsakov's *Russian Easter Overture* is elation and hope fulfilled. Presumably, the form is just the musical structures that comprise the work. But the content is not "contained" in the musical structures. The content would not exist apart from the musical structures. There is no elation here independent of the musical structures. The container/contained model presupposes that the two terms are separable. But the content of the *Russian Easter Overture*—elation—is not separable from the form in the way that the champagne is separable from the bottle.

One might say that the content of the *Russian Easter Overture* is really Easter and elation is the form. But elation doesn't sound like the sort of thing that we think of as form. If we employ the contained/container metaphor, elation seems more like the kind of thing that would be contained in something else. But then we are back to the problem of the previous paragraph, since the elation in the piece does not appear separable from the musical structure.

In order to avoid the problem of the container/contained analogy, the neoformalist may explicate the form/content distinction in another way. The content of an artwork may be said to be its meaning—its theme—or whatever it is about. Form, then, is the mode of presentation of its meaning, the way in which its meaning is made to appear, the way it is embodied, presented or articulated. Its mode of presentation is that which gives form (in the sense of embodiment) to meaning. One might think of the content of an artwork as its essence and form as the mode of appearance of that essence.

For example, the content, subject matter, meaning or theme of *The Fall of Icarus* is the way in which epoch-making history passes us by unnoticed. That is what the painting is about. The form of the work is how this theme is pictured. This theme is articulated by decentering the subject of the painting—Icarus's legendary fall—off to one side where it is likely to be missed (at least at first glance), thereby presenting and reinforcing the meaning of the work through its visual appearance.

The content of an artwork, then, is its meaning—what it is about; the form is the mode of presentation of the meaning, the way in which what it is about is made manifest or is articulated. Yet, every sentence has content and

form in this sense, but not every sentence is an artwork. According to the neoformalist, what distinguishes artworks from other things that have form and content is that in artworks form and content are related in a satisfyingly appropriate manner. But what is "a satisfyingly appropriate manner?"

Let us consult *The Fall of Icarus* again. As we have seen, its theme is that history passes by unnoticed, a truth that strikes an arresting chord for many. Who knew in the late 1950s and early 1960s that we were living in the Golden Age of rock 'n' roll? *The Fall of Icarus* makes this point by placing the major event in the painting in such a way that it goes unnoticed. The decentered composition functions to provide an object lesson in the way in which legendary events can pass by unremarked, since the painting presents Icarus's fall in a way that we are apt to miss it.

Instead of looking at Icarus, we are likely to be wrapped up in the serenity of the overall composition of the painting, as inattentive to Icarus's plight as the farmer is. This is an extremely effective way of getting the point of the painting across. The very design of the painting brings its meaning home to us. It is a deftly suitable means for making us aware of what the painting is about. In that sense, the form is appropriate to the content.

Indeed, it is satisfyingly appropriate to the subject, since when we contemplate how Bruegel has articulated his meaning, we are disposed to say "How clever, how very suitable, how ingenious." The form fits or matches the meaning, and when we reflect upon the match between the meaning and the form, we feel satisfaction in seeing a job neatly done. The unity of meaning and form here abets a satisfying feeling of completeness that we might express by saying that in *The Fall of Icarus* meaning and form suit each other in a way that is "just right," or even "perfect."

Neoformalism has a number of advantages over formalism. According to neoformalism, the possession of a form that is satisfyingly appropriate to its content is necessary and sufficient for art status. Wherever an artifact matches its meaning with a suitably satisfying mode of presentation, it is art. Since this acknowledges that content can be relevant to art status, it avoids many of the most troublesome counterexamples to formalism. For instance, whereas *The Fall of Icarus* was an embarrassment for formalism, it can serve as a paradigmatic example for neoformalism.

That many artworks are intended to serve religious, political, intellectual, emotional and broader social purposes presents no difficulties for the neoformalist. Such work will count as art so long as those purposes are articulated and embodied in modes of presentation appropriate to their meaning. If the mode of presentation mismatched the purposes of a given work, the neoformalist might ask, why would we count it as an artwork anyway? A sermon that boringly recounted the tenets of a catechism is not art, but one whose rhythms raised hope might well be. Isn't this the kind of result we expect?

Neoformalism is also sensitive to the expressive dimensions of artworks. Where we say that the painting is lively or expresses liveliness, neoformalism counts the expression of liveliness as the content or meaning of the painting—as what it is about—and then asks whether the formal means of the painting—its lines, colors and choice of subject matter—are suitable for articulating that expressive property.

Formalism, in contrast, only attends to the structural forms of such paintings and ignores their relation to supervening human qualities. "Liveliness" does not sound like the name of a significant form. Thus, formalism is severely challenged by the fact that we often classify artifacts as art in virtue of their human qualities, their possession of expressive properties. But this liability does not confront the neoformalist.

Another advantage of neoformalism over mere formalism is that it can handle cases like Cage's 4' 33?. If the meaning of Cage's work is that ordinary sounds are worth attending to, then he has discovered a strikingly effective mode of presentation for promoting that insight. He has arranged the performance situation in such a way that all one has left to listen to is ambient sound. This is a devilishly economical strategy for getting us to listen to what usually goes unnoticed—to what we customarily filter out as noise. It prompts us to contemplate noise for its own sake—to remark upon its texture and contrasts. The structure of the piece, in other words, functions to make its meaning manifest, almost unavoidable. That is, the neoformalist, unlike the formalist, can acknowledge that 4' 33? and other experiments like it are art. For according to the neoformalist, 4' 33? does have a form that is satisfyingly appropriate to its content.

A further strength of neoformalism versus formalism is that the notion of the satisfying appropriateness of form to content seems more informative and less obscure than the notion of significant form. Of course, one cannot antecedently list every type of appropriate form, since artists are always discovering new ones; that's what creativity is all about. But since the notion of appropriate form is tied to the meaning of the artwork, where we are able to identify the meaning of the work, we are in a position to determine whether it has been implemented effectively—whether the articulation promotes and reinforces it. Content, in other words, governs our determination of appropriate form. Knowing the content puts us in a position to isolate the elements that give rise to it and then to assess the suitability of those elements to advancing whatever the work is about.

But the case for neoformalism does not rest solely with its ability to recuperate the shortfalls of formalism. There are also independent considerations on its behalf. These do not take the form of deductive arguments, but rather arguments to the best explanation. That is, neoformalism is promoted on the grounds that it does the best job of explaining certain distinctive features of our artistic practices. So, if we

expect our theories of art to make our artistic practices intelligible to us, then, the neoformalist argues, her view is attractive because it explains features of our artistic practices better than its predecessors.

What are some of the features of our artistic practices that neoformalism supposedly excels in explaining? One phenomenon is artistic change. Art is in perpetual motion. Styles mutate constantly. Why should this be? If the imitation theory of art were true, one would have expected the evolution of painting to halt, once artists discovered the pictorial secrets of realism. And if formalism were true, couldn't we predict a point in history when all the significant forms have been discovered? But we believe that art is restless; that it will always be developing new forms. How can this be?

The neoformalist explains this by pointing out that as history marches onwards, human situations change, and, as human situations change, new issues arise, people have new things to say, and artworks have new things to be about. New content mandates new forms—new forms of satisfying appropriateness are thus called forth. Form changes because content changes, where new content requires unprecedented, yet suitable modes of presentation. Artistic style is always transforming because new content impels the search for new forms of articulation. And this is exactly what one would expect, if neoformalism were true.

Connected to its explanation of why artistic forms change is the neoformalist's explanation of why we cherish art. New times call for new meanings, new ideas, new subjects, in short, for new content. Art serves to articulate this new content—to raise new questions and to reassess old verities—in the life of ever-changing communities. Art examines these issues and articulates them in ways that invite reflection. It gives body to the expression of new values, as well as to old ones in new times. And this is why art is important to social life.

Additionally, neoformalism makes sense out of our critical and appreciative practices. Characteristically, critics spend a great deal of their time interpreting artworks and calling attention to distinctive elements in the artworks that they interpret. They weave back and forth between disclosing the meaning of the work and then pointing to the parts of the artwork that are relevant to its meaning. A literary critic may call attention to the breathless pace of a poem like Tennyson's *The Charge of the Light Brigade* and then remind us that its subject is a relentless cavalry assault. What the critic is doing is relating a structural feature of the poem —its cadence—to what the poem is about. Her purpose is to show that the form of the poem, the way it is articulated, is appropriate to its meaning— that it is ideally suited, or, at least, well suited to expressing it.

Moreover, the neoformalist adds, this practice makes perfect sense, if what an artwork is essentially is a matter of fitting form to content. The critic, in such cases, is gesturing toward exactly what makes the relevant

artifact art. She is revealing the *artistic* value in the work—the way in which the work works well as an artwork.

Of course, attending to the marriage of form and content is not just something that only critics do. This is often what we noncritics do as well. In this regard, critics are just special cases—exemplary, and frequently professional—representatives of what common folk do when responding to artworks. The critics help us by showing us where to look and how to understand what we find. But in this, their practices are merely a more refined extension of one of the central ways in which we all appreciate artworks.

Ordinary readers, viewers and listeners also ask why artworks are organized in the way they are and most frequently they answer that question by reference to the content of the work. And where the mode of articulation is fitting or particularly relevant or apposite to the work's content, we derive a satisfying sense of unity from the artist's craftsmanship in matching form with content.

This is how we go about appreciating artworks, whether we are critics or plain audience members. That this behavior lies at the heart of our appreciative practices accords trimly with neoformalism. For if what is special about artworks is the relation of fitness between form and content, then reflecting on that fitness would appear to be the natural way to respond to what is uniquely artistic about artworks. Thus, neoformalism offers a very illuminating account of our appreciative practices, whether we are critics or only nonprofessional or plain viewers, listeners or readers.

Neoformalism can also say something about what it is that artists do. What makes an artist different from a scientist, a doctor, or a lawyer? What is her special area of expertise? This is a question that Plato raised in several of his dialogues. The neoformalist answer is straightforward. The artist is essentially a specialist in matching modes of presentation and meanings, in marrying forms to content.

In sum, neoformalism is superior to formalism because it can acknowledge the importance of representational content for art. Conversely, it is superior to representational theories of art because it emphasizes that content alone is not sufficient for art status; form is at least equally indispensable. Neoformalism is also alert to the expressive dimension of artworks, regarding expressive properties as what the relevant artworks are about and form as their manner of embodiment. In addition, neoformalism can explain what artists are, why art changes, why we value art, and why critical and lay appreciation take the form they do. All in all, neoformalism is a powerful theory of art. It is the best candidate as a comprehensive theory of all art reviewed thus far. But even so, it has its problems.

According to neoformalism, x is an artwork if and only if (1) x has content; (2) x has form; and (3) the form and content of x are related in a satisfyingly appropriate manner. The requirement that x have content

reminds us of the neorepresentational theory of art and it is susceptible to the same kind of objections raised against that theory in the first chapter of this book.

The neoformalist says that x is art only if x has content—a meaning, something that x is about. This is a necessary condition for art. But as we have already seen, not all art meets this condition. Some art has no meaning. Some art is exclusively devoted to producing an effect in audiences. Some art is designed to delight by means of its appearance. The abstract grillwork on a palace gate might be an example here. It possesses no distinctive expressive properties. It simply pleasures the eye with its look, and, moreover, this is all that it is intended to do. Therefore, meaning cannot be a necessary condition of all art; some art is "below" meaning. Such artworks may be simply beautiful. They are bereft of content; there is nothing they are about. Much pure orchestral music and pure dance might also be described this way.

But the neoformalist is not likely to take this objection lying down. He might argue that there is a way in which such art does have content. Though abstract painting and orchestral music do not appear to have content in the sense that they do not refer to perceptible events nor have themes nor express points of view about anything, they do have structures which produce effects in audiences—that cause pleasure and absorption.

The content of such works, the neoformalist then suggests, are the rhythms, aural and visual devices, and arrangements of elements that command audience attention, that pleasure us, or that absorb us. The artist puts these structures forward not only in order to move us in certain ways, but to enable us to reflect upon how we are moved by them. These structures address our human sensibilities, and, in that way, reveal the nature and contours of our sensibilities to us.

Such artworks show us, often to our surprise, that we are the kind of creatures capable of finding pleasure in, for example, having a bow drawn across taut cat guts (a.k.a. violins) in a certain way. Artists who manipulate appearances for the sake of delivering beauty and engendering pleasure are in fact also fundamentally involved in exploring human sensibility. Their works enable us to make discoveries about ourselves—about the kinds of creatures we are at the level of our perceptual sensibilities. These works are, then, about something; they are about the human sensorium— its capacities, its proclivities, and, perhaps, its limits. They have a meaning; they tell us about who and what we are.

Undoubtedly, this account of artworks is true in some cases. It does a good job describing the work of many Minimalist artists, such as the sculptor Donald Judd and the composer Philip Glass. These artists intend their works to have a reflexive dimension—they are about themselves in the sense that they encourage audiences to reflect upon their own

experiences of the work in question (to reflect, for example, on the way in which various repetitive progressions affect one's temporal consciousness of the music). These works are meant to invite an apperceptive response in spectators—they extend an invitation to attend to the way that we attend to the artwork.

But not all abstract music and painting has this reflexive or apperceptive dimension. Much absorbs us without guiding us to reflect upon or to contemplate the conditions of our absorption. Much art engages us with its sheer beauty, without inviting us to stand back and ask from whence that sense of beauty springs. Minimalist art generally succeeds in educing a reflexive stance toward our experience of it by its austerity, by leaving us with little else to contemplate except the way the artwork addresses us along certain very restricted parameters of sensibility. The minimal (austere) structure of Minimalist art (that's why it's called *Minimalism*) compels us to take an apperceptive stance. But this is not the case with all abstract painting and music. It may engage our sensibilities—engage them richly—without encouraging us to interrogate the sources of that engagement. That is, it may be so rich and command our attention so overwhelmingly that we have neither the time nor the inclination to ponder the origin of its power. Much tap dancing is like this. Such works may and most frequently do lack the kind of internal structuring strategies that allow us to say of Minimalism what it is about or comments upon the nature of our human sensibilities.

But if such artworks do not encourage an apperceptive stance in audiences and do not possess the kinds of internal structures that invite it, what sense does it make to say that these works are about exploring our human sensibilities? Many artworks engage our sensibilities, even quite pleasurably, without being about our capacities for pleasure. To be about our capacities for pleasurable engagement surely requires more than just being pleasurable. A candy bar is pleasurable, but it is not about pleasure. It is not reflexive.

Similarly, unless they contain special internal structures that allude to or draw our attention to our capacities for absorption, there are no grounds to suppose that all "meaningless" artworks are really about our capacities for absorption. Most have the more mundane task of stimulating our senses in various ways, not the more recondite, reflexive goal of engendering reflection on the nature of human sensibility. This cannot be their "meaning" or content. Therefore, some works of art are not about anything. They have no subject or content. Therefore, content is not a necessary condition for art.

The neoformalist also contends that x is art only if it has form. This condition is a bit tricky; evaluating it depends on what we mean by "form." If we interpret "form" in some ways, it is clearly false. For example, if we mean by having form "having parts that are related to each other in some

way or other," then, though the condition will hold for anything, including any artwork, that has discernible parts, it will not obtain for artworks that have no discernible parts, such as monochromatic paintings whose coloration is uniform throughout the picture plane.

But this, of course, is not the sense of form that we have attributed to the neoformalist. We have suggested that, for the neoformalist, form amounts to the way in which the meaning or content of an artwork is articulated—how meaning is embodied, its mode of presentation. However, this notion of form has at least one very obvious limitation. If form is necessarily correlative with meaning or content—if it requires content in order to subsist—then a work without meaning or content can have no form in this sense. And since there are some artworks bereft of meaning or content—artworks that are about nothing—then the neoformalist must concede that, in his sense of form, form cannot be a necessary condition of art.

One might try to find a more promising sense of form for the neoformalist. One candidate could be that the form of the work is nothing other than the appearance or shape of the work in the same way that the term "the human form" is interchangeable with "the human body." However, this usage seems inadmissibly broad with respect to artworks, since when we refer to the form of an artwork, we generally mean something less than its total appearance.

The third necessary condition in the neoformalist theory of art is that "x is an artwork only if the form and the content of x are related in a satisfyingly appropriate manner." Insofar as this condition depends on the concepts of form and content, it inherits the preceding objections. But the condition also raises new problems. It returns us, once again, to the issue of bad art.

Some art is bad. A common reason for badness in art is that an artwork fails to find a satisfyingly appropriate form for its content. But something does not cease to be an artwork because it is bad. It is still an artwork, but only a bad *artwork*. We find ourselves frequently saying, "I saw that artwork [a play, for example] last night, but it was a bad artwork [a bad play]." We don't say, "I didn't see an artwork." But the neoformalist cannot account for this. For if something fails to find a satisfyingly appropriate form for its content, it is not, so neoformalism implies, an artwork at all. The upshot of neoformalism is that all artworks, properly so called, are good—all are salutary achievements, since anything that is an artwork has discovered a satisfyingly appropriate form for its content. And how could anything like that be bad?

Instead of a comprehensive, classificatory theory of art, neoformalism turns out to be a commendatory theory of art—a theory that tracks only good art, art worthy of commendation for its satisfying marriage of form and content. But this overlooks all the bad art which, in fact, probably

outnumbers the good art exponentially. Thus, the satisfying appropriateness of form to content cannot be a necessary condition of art.

Needless to say, neoformalists are aware of this objection and they are quick to provide a remedy. It is this: there is bad art, as ordinary usage indicates, but badness in art is a function of possessing very low degrees of satisfying appropriateness. Bad artworks are art; they possess satisfying appropriateness, but in very low quantities.

There are several problems with this gambit. First, one wonders how anything that has found a *satisfyingly* appropriate match of form to content could be bad, in any straightforward sense. But second, and oddly enough, badness here seems to be nothing more than the absence of goodness (goodness to a minimal degree), insofar as satisfying appropriateness must always count as a good-making property in artworks. Yet aren't some defects in artworks absolute blemishes in their own right, not just substandard virtues (appropriateness below some stipulated threshold)?

An artwork can be unsatisfyingly inappropriate formally in every way; bad science fiction films and sidewalk paintings at art fairs are often like this. They are not bad because they are not formally appropriate enough. They are total disasters. The problem is not that they are insufficiently good; they are altogether bad. The neoformalist's redefinition of badness as diminished goodness thus seems dubious. Moreover, since there is positive badness and not merely negative goodness to be found in art, even with this reconstrual of badness, the requirement of satisfyingly appropriate form cannot serve as a necessary condition for art, since it excludes from the order of art positively bad art—art that is unsatisfyingly inappropriate formally with no quotient of satisfyingly appropriate form.

Possibly some will say that that's okay. Sometimes an attempt at art can be so bad that we should not count it as art as all. So maybe the neoformalist is onto something important. To create an artwork is an achievement of sorts. An artwork, thus, cannot be altogether bad. It must have some goodness. Perhaps that involves some minimal matching of form to content. Badness in art is just a lack of a sufficient amount of satisfyingly appropriate form.

But there are two problems here. The first is obvious, namely: what is a sufficient amount of appropriateness and how do we measure it? Can this be done without courting arbitrariness? But there is also a deeper problem. Appropriateness or satisfying appropriateness is a matter of degrees. We might call appropriateness a degree concept. But being an artwork is not a matter of degrees. Rather, something is art or it is not art. Let's call this an either/or concept. For example, someone is either a virgin or not; one can't be a little bit of both.

Moreover, one cannot use a degree concept, except stipulatively, to define an either/or concept. You can't be 85 per cent virgin and 15 per cent

innocent. Virginity is a done deal, not a matter of degrees. But if this is so—if degree concepts are ill-suited to define either/or concepts—then there is a deep problem with the neoformalist's attempt to define art in terms of satisfyingly appropriate form. Appropriateness—or satisfying appropriateness—are degree concepts, not either/or concepts, and, therefore, they are not the right sort of concepts logically for defining art. Artness or arthood or art status is not a matter of degree.

But suppose the neoformalist attempts to resolve this inadequacy by stipulating a cut-off point—a threshold below which a work's amount of formal appropriateness is not sufficient to count as art. It is hard to imagine that the results of such a gesture could be satisfactory. For any such boundary will appear arbitrary to anyone whose work falls below it. Constant disputes will arise along the border between art and nonart. And the disenfranchished will have good reasons on their side, since the disputed works will have at least some admitted degree of formal appropriateness. For satisfying appropriateness to provide a litmus test for art status, some nonarbitrary principle must be found for determining what amount of degree of formal appropriateness is just enough. But that seems a hopeless task.

In our discussion of the neoformalist's problem with bad art, the reader may be surprised that it was not suggested that it be resolved by replacing the requirement of formal appropriateness with the more modest requirement that the formal appropriateness merely be intended by the artist. Thus, an artwork need not achieve a satisfyingly appropriate match of form to content, but only be intended to achieve it. Bad art then would be art where there was an intention to discover formal appropriateness, but where the intention went unrealized. Would this save neoformalism?

Not really. In order to see this, we need only shift our attention from considering the necessity of each of the conditions individually to asking whether the conditions are jointly sufficient for defining all and only art. They are not, since many artifacts that are not art have form and content that are not only related in satisfyingly appropriate ways, but which are intended to be so related.

The packaging of ordinary household products, for example, has a content, something they are about, namely the product that they contain, about which they say something through their carefully selected designs. Ordinary Brillo boxes, for instance, are about the product Brillo, about which they say something by means of their shapes and colors. They have a meaning that they communicate intentionally through their form. The bright colors associate Brillo with sparkliness and their wavelike shapes suggest cleansing qualities.

The formal articulation of an ordinary Brillo box is appropriate—even satisfyingly so—since it matches the intended meaning of its producers.

There can be no doubt that Brillo boxes project Proctor and Gamble's idea of their product in an economical, appropriate, and even imaginative way. But ordinary Brillo boxes are not art, even if Andy Warhol's appropriation of them is.

Nor is this a rare example. Many cultural artifacts match their content with satisfyingly appropriate forms. That is what commercial design is all about. If campers express solidity, their squared-off shapes articulate it. If sunglasses are about coolness, their clean streamlines have a lot to do with it. The labels on bottles of mouthwash have content, have meanings, and are about something. The companies that sell them hire armies of graphic designers to articulate it—to find an appropriate form for the content. Sometimes they succeed. But have you ever seen a bottle of mouthwash in a grocery store that you would call art? Yet might not a neoformalist have to?

Cultural artifacts—including gestures and behaviors—of all sorts have content and are freighted with meanings. Maybe most are. And, additionally, quite of few of them articulate their meanings by means of appropriate forms, ones that we can stand back from and admire for their satisfying economy, unity, coherence, and so on. But not all such cultural productions are art; ordinary Brillo boxes are not. And yet, by the same token, it is hard to see how neoformalism can deny them art status. Thus, though an initially promising comprehensive theory of art, neoformalism appears ultimately too inclusive and must be rejected for that reason.